



MAMATA BANERJEE AND SONIA GANDHI'S ALLIANCE WIPES OUT THE LEFT IN THE ASSEMBLY BYPOLLS

DELHI | The Gender Bender

Women, it seems, are getting the better of men. Electorally at least. The latest round of 31 Assembly by-elections spread across seven states has Sonia Gandhi, Mamata Banerjee and Mayawati beaming while the news has been bitter for Mulayam Singh Yadav and the Left parties. In the most high-profile contest, the Congress wrested the Firozabad Lok Sabha seat from the SP as its candidate Raj Babbar trounced Dimple Yadav, daughter-in-law of the SP supremo, by over 85,000 votes. The Congress credits General Secretary Rahul Gandhi for this win as he had campaigned against the SP's star-studded bandwagon. Of the 11 Assembly bypolls in Uttar Pradesh, the BSP won nine even though Mayawati did not campaign. That five of these were held by the SP can only add to Mulayam's woes. In the Left parties, there is a sense of dark foreboding after the CPI(M) failed to win a single seat in the 13 Assembly by-elections in West Bengal and Kerala. Of the 10 seats in West Bengal, the Left held three and Trinamool Congress five in 2006. This time Trinamool won seven. A jubilant Banerjee calls this a runup to the Assembly polls slated for 2011. In Kerala, the CPI(M)'s nose was rubbed in dirt as the Congress candidate who romped to victory in Kannur was A.P. Abdullakutty a two-time CPI(M) MP who was recently thrown out of the party. The BJP's run of bad luck continued. It could not win a single seat in Uttar Pradesh and its misery was compounded as the Congress took two of its seats away—one each from Uttar Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. Earlier, when countering the criticism that it had lost the three state Assembly polls to the Congress, the BJP used to point to the last round of 49 byelections in September where it won 12 to the Congress tally of 10. This time the story is rather different. Of the 31 Assembly seats, the Congress has won 10 and the BJP only two. For the BJP, the message is ominous; when the centre cannot hold, the states will unravel as well.

by Priya Sahgal

Of the 31 Assembly bypolls spread over seven states, the Congress won 10, the BSP nine and the Trinamool seven. Both the CPI(M) and the SP were humbled, with the SP even failing to retain the Firozabad Lok Sabha seat.